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Decoding Portfolios: A Qualitative Document Analysis of Reflective Growth, Learning Quality, and Professional Readiness Among BTLED Fourth-Year Students

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ABSTRACT

Portfolio assessment can provide authentic documentary evidence of pre-service teachers' development, but limited evidence explains how reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness are manifested together in Bachelor of Technology and Livelihood Education (BTLED) portfolios in the Philippine context. This study employed qualitative document analysis to examine the completed teaching portfolios of seven fourth-year BTLED pre-service teachers from Ifugao State University–Potia Campus. A researcher-adapted coding matrix organized documentary evidence into three dimensions reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness using four indicators per dimension and a four-level evidence scale from Emerging (E1) to Advanced (E4). The analysis showed advanced evidence for progression of learning, reflective depth, identity formation, organization and structure, competency alignment, authenticity of artifacts, quality of outputs, teaching competence, theory-to-practice integration, professional identity and ethics, and employability readiness; documentation of challenges and resolutions was assessed as Proficient (E3). Cross-portfolio analysis highlighted recurring patterns of professional identity formation, instructional competence, reflective practice, and preparation for employment. The findings suggest that portfolios can function as more than collections of course requirements: they can document how pre-service teachers connect experience, reflection, instructional work, and professional development. However, the findings represent documented evidence within a small purposively selected group and should not be interpreted as direct evidence of actual employment outcomes or generalized teacher competence. The study therefore supports strengthening portfolio design and assessment while recognizing the need for more systematic validation and multi-coder procedures in future research.

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1. INTRODUCTION

Teaching portfolios have become an important component of teacher education because they assemble authentic evidence of learning, instructional practice, reflection, and professional development. Unlike assessments that capture performance at a single point in time, portfolios can document how pre-service teachers plan instruction, select and develop learning materials, assess learners, respond to classroom experiences, and reflect on their professional growth. Darling-Hammond and Snyder (2000) emphasized the value of authentic performance evidence in assessing teacher competence, while Lyons (1998) positioned portfolios as a means of making professional learning and reflection visible.

Portfolios are also suitable documentary sources for qualitative inquiry because they preserve naturally occurring records of educational experiences. Bowen (2009) describes document analysis as a systematic process of reviewing and interpreting documents to generate meaning, while the present study applies this approach to teaching artifacts rather than relying on participants' retrospective accounts alone. The portfolio therefore provides an opportunity to examine what pre-service teachers actually documented about their learning, instructional decisions, reflections, and developing professional identity.

Recent scholarship continues to associate portfolio assessment with reflection, authentic assessment, professional identity, and professional development. Nguyen (2021) synthesized literature showing the role of portfolios in promoting reflection in teacher education. Beka and Kulinxha (2021) likewise emphasized portfolios as tools for self-reflection and professional development, while Boholano *et al.* (2022) documented the use of e-portfolios in Philippine teacher education institutions. More recent work has further connected portfolio assessment with metacognitive growth and professional identity (Ferreira, 2026) and with reflection, professional identity, and digital preparedness in pre-service teacher education (Zainuddin *et al.*, 2026). These studies suggest that portfolios can capture multiple dimensions of teacher development, but they also point to the need to examine how such dimensions are evidenced together within specific teacher education contexts.

Despite this growing literature, a contextual and analytical gap remains. Existing studies commonly emphasize reflective practice, authentic assessment, e-portfolios, professional identity, or professional development as distinct concerns. Less attention has been given to how reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness can be examined simultaneously through the documentary evidence contained in BTLED teaching portfolios in a Philippine state-university context. The present study addresses this gap by analyzing seven completed portfolios using a common coding framework. It contributes a focused account of the kinds of evidence that appear across portfolios and the patterns that emerge when those documents are examined comparatively.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

Although the literature establishes the usefulness of portfolios for reflection, authentic assessment, professional identity, and teacher development, the studies reviewed do not fully address how these dimensions are simultaneously manifested in BTLED

pre-service teachers' completed teaching portfolios in the Philippine state-university setting. The present study therefore takes a documentary and cross-portfolio perspective. Rather than treating portfolio scores as direct measures of teacher effectiveness, it examines the documented evidence available in the portfolios and interprets recurring patterns across three dimensions: reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness. This analytical position also recognizes the limits of documentary evidence: what is absent from a portfolio cannot automatically be interpreted as absent from the participant's actual competence, and evidence of employability readiness should be understood as documented preparation rather than verified employment success.

2.1. Research gap and analytical position

The study draws on complementary theoretical perspectives. Dewey's (1933) view of reflective thought explains why experience becomes educationally meaningful when learners examine and reconstruct it through reflection. Schön's (1983) conception of reflective practice further emphasizes teachers' examination of their actions and decisions in practice. Bandura's (1986) Social Cognitive Theory provides a basis for interpreting developing professional confidence and self-efficacy through authentic performance experiences. Biggs' (1996) constructive alignment also informs the analysis of learning quality by emphasizing coherence among intended learning outcomes, teaching activities, and assessment. These perspectives collectively support an interpretation of portfolio evidence as a record of learning, reflection, instructional application, and professional development.

2.2. Theoretical foundations

Portfolio work can also support the formation of professional identity and readiness. Haghighi Irani *et al.* (2020) examined professional identity construction among pre-service teachers, while Lewis and Gerbic (2012) showed how e-portfolios can be used to address professional standards and professional learning. Zhao and Zhang (2017) likewise linked field teaching practice with the development of pre-service teachers' professional identity. In the Philippine context, Boholano *et al.* (2022) documented the use of e-portfolios in higher education teacher education institutions, demonstrating the relevance of portfolio-based practices within local teacher preparation. More recent studies extend this discussion to metacognitive growth, professional identity, and digital preparedness (Ferreira, 2026; Zainuddin *et al.*, 2026). These findings support examining portfolios as developmental records while cautioning that documented readiness should not automatically be equated with actual employment performance.

2.3. Professional identity, readiness, and the teacher education context

Portfolio assessment is also linked to authentic assessment because portfolio artifacts can represent tasks and products that resemble real teaching work. Gulikers (2007) conceptualized authenticity in assessment through the relationship between the task, context, social processes, and criteria, while Hodgman (2014) discussed student portfolios as a way of facilitating



teaching and learning through authentic assessment. Ozan (2019) further reported positive relationships between authentic assessment and prospective teachers' academic achievement and attitudes toward educational measurement. From this perspective, learning quality in a teaching portfolio can be examined through the organization of artifacts, alignment with intended competencies, authenticity of evidence, and quality of outputs rather than through document quantity alone.

2.4. Authentic assessment and learning quality

Portfolio assessment is grounded in the view that learning and professional development can be demonstrated through a purposeful collection of authentic evidence. In teacher education, lesson plans, teaching materials, assessment tools, reflective journals, observation records, and other artifacts can make instructional thinking and professional learning visible. Lyons (1998) argued that portfolios can document the complex processes through which teachers develop professional knowledge, while Beka and Kulinxha (2021) highlighted their role in self-reflection and professional development. Dumlao and Pinatacan (2019) similarly demonstrated the value of reflective journal writing in supporting pre-service teachers' professional development. Together, these studies indicate that the value of a portfolio lies not merely in the number of artifacts collected but in the connections that the artifacts reveal among experience, reflection, and professional learning.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1. Research design

This study employed qualitative document analysis (QDA) to examine the teaching portfolios of seven Bachelor of Technology and Livelihood Education (BTLED) fourth-year pre-service teachers. The design was selected because the study sought to interpret documentary evidence of reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness without manipulating the setting or asking participants to reconstruct experiences solely through interviews. Consistent with Bowen (2009), the analysis involved systematic examination, interpretation, categorization, and comparison of documentary evidence.

The analysis was guided by a predefined coding framework containing three dimensions and twelve indicators. The unit of analysis was the documentary evidence relevant to each indicator within each portfolio. The framework was used to maintain analytic consistency across the seven portfolios while allowing qualitative notes to capture the meaning and context of the evidence.

3.2. Data source

The primary data sources were the completed teaching portfolios of seven (7) fourth-year BTLED pre-service teachers from Ifugao State University–Potia Campus who had successfully completed practice teaching. Purposive selection was used because the portfolios were required to contain sufficient documentary evidence relevant to all three study dimensions. The selection criteria applied to the available portfolios were: (1) completion of the practice-teaching requirement; (2) submission of a completed teaching portfolio; (3) presence of substantive evidence such as lesson plans,

instructional materials, assessment tools, reflective journals, observation records, and supporting professional documents; and (4) authorized access to the portfolio for research purposes. Portfolios that did not meet the documentary requirements were not included. These criteria were intended to ensure comparability and adequate documentary coverage rather than statistical representativeness.

3.3. Document analysis tool

A researcher-adapted document analysis tool was used to examine the portfolios. The matrix was constructed from the study objectives and the portfolio-assessment and teacher-development literature reviewed in the study. It contained three dimensions: Reflective Growth, Learning Quality, and Professional Readiness with four indicators under each dimension. The matrix functioned as an analytic guide rather than as a psychometric scale. Because the original study record does not document a formal external validation procedure, the instrument is not described as formally validated; instead, its content alignment with the objectives and relevant literature is made explicit.

Reflective Growth covered progression of learning, reflective depth, identity formation, and documentation of challenges and resolutions. Learning Quality covered organization and structure, alignment with competencies, authenticity of artifacts, and quality of outputs. Professional Readiness covered teaching competence, theory-to-practice integration, professional identity and ethics, and employability readiness.

The four-level coding scale was interpreted as follows: E1 (Emerging) indicated limited or beginning documentary evidence; E2 (Developing) indicated partially established evidence with noticeable gaps; E3 (Proficient) indicated clear and adequate evidence; and E4 (Advanced) indicated strong, consistent, and well-developed evidence across the relevant portfolio materials. The coding level refers to the strength and completeness of documentary evidence, not to an absolute measurement of the participant's overall teaching competence.

Table 1. Coding framework for the qualitative document analysis of teaching portfolios.

Dimension	Indicators	Coding Scale
Reflective Growth	Progression of Learning;	E1 – Emerging
	Reflective Depth;	E2 – Developing
	Identity Formation;	E3 – Proficient
	Documentation of Challenges and Resolutions	E4 – Advanced
Learning Quality	Organization and Structure;	E1 – Emerging
	Alignment with Competencies;	E2 – Developing
	Authenticity of Artifacts	E3 – Proficient
	Quality of Outputs	E4 – Advanced
Professional Readiness	Teaching Competence;	E1 – Emerging
	Theory-to-Practice Integration;	E2 – Developing



Professional Identity and Ethics;	E3 – Proficient
Employability Readiness	E4 – Advanced

3.4. Data collection procedure

Prior to the study, permission was obtained from the appropriate university authorities to access and analyze the teaching portfolios, and informed consent was secured from the participants. The researchers gathered the seven completed portfolios and checked each document against the selection criteria and required documentary components. The portfolios were then assigned coded identifiers, organized by portfolio, and prepared for systematic analysis. Identifying information was excluded from the analytic record used for reporting.

3.5. Data analysis procedure

The portfolios were analyzed iteratively. First, each portfolio was read in full to establish familiarity with its contents. Second, documentary evidence was extracted and organized according to the twelve indicators in the coding matrix. Third, evidence was assigned an E1–E4 level based on the defined criteria, and qualitative analytic notes were recorded to explain the basis for each coding decision. Fourth, evidence across portfolios was compared to identify convergent and divergent patterns. Finally, recurring patterns were synthesized into the three study dimensions and the cross-portfolio themes reported in the findings. This sequence was intended to preserve a traceable connection between source documents, coding decisions, and interpretations.

The documentary materials examined included lesson plans, instructional materials, assessment tools, reflective journals, classroom observation records, photographs, certificates, and other teaching-related outputs included in the portfolios. Coding focused on evidence directly relevant to the indicators and did not assign a level solely because an artifact was present. Where evidence was incomplete or varied in depth, the lower level was retained, and the variation was documented in the analytic notes.

Following coding, the researchers conducted cross-portfolio comparison to identify similarities, differences, and recurring patterns. Thematic synthesis was then used to organize these patterns under the three analytic dimensions and to identify broader recurring themes, including professional identity formation, instructional competence, reflective practice, and employment readiness. No numerical aggregation beyond the descriptive E1–E4 evidence levels was used to claim statistical generalization.

3.6. Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness was addressed through credibility, dependability, confirmability, and transferability following Lincoln and Guba (1985). Credibility was supported by repeated reading of the complete portfolios, use of a common coding framework, and grounding interpretations in documentary evidence. Dependability was addressed by maintaining an audit trail of coding decisions, qualitative notes, and analytic procedures. Confirmability was strengthened by linking interpretations to identifiable documentary evidence within coded portfolios rather than to personal assumptions. Transferability was supported through description of the institutional context, participant group, portfolio contents, selection criteria, and analytic procedures. The researcher's role was limited to organizing, coding, comparing, and interpreting the documentary evidence; potential interpretive bias was managed by applying the same coding definitions across all portfolios and by retaining analytic notes that made coding decisions explicit.

A methodological limitation should be noted. The original study record does not document an independent second-coder procedure or an inter-rater reliability coefficient. Accordingly, no inter-rater reliability statistic is claimed in this revised manuscript. Future replication should incorporate independent double-coding of a portion of the portfolios and report an appropriate agreement procedure to strengthen the dependability of the coding framework.

3.7. Ethical considerations

This research maintained ethical standards across the overall process. Coded identifiers during data analysis and reporting were used, and all identifying information was removed to protect participants' privacy. The teaching portfolios were used strictly for academic and research purposes and treated with confidentiality. The researchers additionally ensured that the findings accurately reflected the documentary evidence without alteration, fabrication, or misinterpretation.

4. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

This section presents the findings from the seven teaching portfolios and interprets them against the study's coding framework and related literature. The E-levels describe the strength of documentary evidence; they should not be interpreted as direct measures of participants' actual competence outside the portfolio. Where appropriate, the discussion distinguishes what the documents demonstrate from what they cannot establish.

4.1. Theme 1. Reflective growth as evidence of professional development

Table 2. Summary of evidence on reflective growth across the teaching portfolios.

Indicator	Level of Evidence	Summary of Evidence
Progression of Learning	E4	Across the seven teaching portfolios of the BTLED Pre-service teachers, improvements in lesson planning, classroom instruction, classroom management, and reflective practice became more evident as the practice teaching progressed. The entries suggest that the pre-service teachers gradually strengthened their teaching competencies through continuous classroom experiences.



Reflective Depth	E4	The reflection journals described the classroom experiences, explained the reasons behind instructional decisions, discussed learners' participation, and identified areas that needed further improvement. These reflections indicate that the pre-service teachers regularly examined their own teaching practices and learning and made sure that they would reflect on it.
Identity Formation	E4	The portfolios provide evidence of the gradual development of professional identity. As the practice teaching continued, the pre-service teachers showed greater confidence, accepted more responsibility, adapted to different classroom situations, and developed a clearer understanding of the responsibilities expected of becoming future teachers.
Documentation of Challenges and Resolutions	E3	The portfolios consistently documented classroom challenges together with corresponding instructional responses and problem-solving strategies, although the depth of reflection and documentation varied among the portfolios.

The seven portfolios showed strong documentary evidence of learning progression, reflective practice, and professional identity formation. Lesson plans, instructional materials, observation records, and reflective entries collectively suggested increasing attention to classroom planning, instructional decisions, classroom management, and self-evaluation. Progression of Learning, Reflective Depth, and Identity Formation were therefore coded E4. Documentation of Challenges and Resolutions was coded E3 because the portfolios did not show the same depth and consistency in explaining challenges, responses, and subsequent adjustments. This distinction is important: the portfolios demonstrate that challenges were documented, but the evidence is less consistent in showing a complete reflective cycle from problem identification to response and subsequent evaluation.

The pattern is consistent with Dewey's (1933) view that reflection transforms experience into learning and with Schön's (1983) emphasis on reflection in and on practice. It also accords with the use of portfolios as evidence of professional learning (Darling-Hammond & Snyder, 2000; Lyons, 1998). However, the uniformly high ratings for three indicators should be interpreted cautiously. Because the analysis relies on selected portfolio evidence, E4 indicates strong documentation rather than proof that every aspect of teaching competence was consistently demonstrated in practice. The lower E3 rating for challenges and resolutions provides useful evidence of variation that might otherwise be obscured by an overall positive profile.

4.2. Theme 2. Learning quality reflected in portfolio artifacts

Table 3. Summary of evidence on learning quality across the teaching portfolios.

Indicator	Level of Evidence	Summary of Evidence
Organization and Structure	E4	Throughout practice teaching, participants showed progressive improvement in lesson planning, classroom instruction, and decision-making as they gained authentic teaching experiences. The portfolios also consistently demonstrated continuous professional and instructional growth.
Alignment with Competencies	E4	Practice teaching requirements, intended learning outcomes, and curriculum standards alignment were consistently reflected in the portfolio artifacts.
Authenticity of Artifacts	E4	Classroom documents that provided credible evidence of the participants' teaching experiences, photographs, assessment tools, authentic instructional materials, and lesson plans were in the portfolio.
Quality of Outputs	E4	The instructional outputs repeatedly showed accuracy, completeness, relevance, and professionalism, which mirrors the participants' proficiency in planning and preparing quality teaching materials.

The portfolios contained lesson plans, learning materials, assessment tools, observation records, and other teaching artifacts that were generally organized and relevant to the documented teaching activities. These artifacts provided evidence that participants were able to translate program requirements into concrete instructional products. Organization and Structure, Alignment with Competencies, Authenticity of Artifacts, and Quality of Outputs were all coded E4 because the documentary evidence was consistently present and substantively connected to practice teaching.

The E4 pattern across Learning Quality indicates a strong documentary alignment between portfolio contents and

practice-teaching requirements. Nevertheless, an all-E4 profile can also reflect the characteristics of the selected portfolios and the coding criteria. The findings therefore support the claim that the portfolios contained strong evidence of learning quality, but they do not establish that all instructional outputs were equally effective for learners. Biggs' (1996) constructive alignment provides a useful interpretive lens because the artifacts show connections among intended competencies, instructional activities, and assessment; however, documentary alignment should not be treated as equivalent to demonstrated learning outcomes.

This interpretation is supported by Biggs (1996) and by



literature on authentic and portfolio-based assessment (Gulikers, 2007; Hodgman, 2014; Ozan, 2019). The portfolios therefore functioned as records of learning experiences and instructional production rather than merely as collections of compliance documents. The strongest contribution of this

finding is the visibility of how course-based knowledge was represented in practice-teaching artifacts.

4.3. Theme 3. Professional readiness for the teaching profession

Table 4. Summary of evidence on professional readiness across the teaching portfolios.

Indicator	Level of Evidence	Summary of Evidence
Teaching Competence	E4	The teaching portfolios repeatedly showed competence in planning, implementing, and assessing instruction through documented classroom teaching experiences, assessment tools, instructional materials, and well-developed lesson plans.
Theory-to-Practice Integration	E4	The portfolios provided consistent evidence of the participants' capability to use learning theories, instructional principles, and teaching methods in authentic classroom scenarios during practice teaching.
Professional Identity and Ethics	E4	The written evidence mirrored the participants' dedication to professional duties, ethical conduct, accountability, and continual self-improvement as future educators.
Employability Readiness	E4	The portfolios showed the readiness of the participants for the teaching profession through comprehensive documentation of instructional competencies, communication skills, adaptability, leadership experiences, and other professional achievements cultivated during practice teaching.

The portfolios supplied substantial documentary evidence of professional preparedness. Teaching Competence, Theory-to-Practice Integration, Professional Identity and Ethics, and Employability Readiness were all coded E4 because the portfolios contained multiple forms of evidence related to instructional planning and implementation, application of learning theories and methods, professional conduct, and preparation for teaching.

The findings can be interpreted in relation to the Philippine Professional Standards for Teachers and Bandura's (1986) Social Cognitive Theory, particularly the role of authentic experiences in developing perceived capability. They also align with research connecting field experiences and portfolio work with professional identity development (Haghighi Irani *et al.*, 2020; Zhao & Zhang, 2017). At the same time, the E4 rating for Employability Readiness requires careful interpretation. The portfolios documented competencies, communication, adaptability, leadership experiences, and professional achievements, but the study did not follow participants into employment. Thus, the finding supports documented preparation for employment, not verified employment success or job performance.

The study has several limitations that should guide interpretation. First, the sample comprised seven purposively selected portfolios from one campus, so the findings are context-specific and are not statistically generalizable to all BTLED pre-service teachers. Second, portfolio evidence is selective and may reflect what participants chose or were required to include; absence of evidence should not be interpreted as absence of competence. Third, the study did not include an independent second coder or report an inter-rater reliability coefficient, limiting the ability to quantify coding agreement. Fourth, employability readiness was inferred from documentary evidence and was not validated against subsequent employment outcomes. Future studies should use larger and more diverse samples, formal external

review of the coding matrix, independent double-coding, and, where feasible, triangulation with observations, interviews, supervisor evaluations, or graduate employment data.

5. CONCLUSION

Using a researcher-adapted coding framework, the study found consistent documentary evidence across three dimensions of portfolio development: reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness. The portfolios showed strong evidence of progression in learning, reflective depth, identity formation, organization and quality of instructional artifacts, theory-to-practice integration, professional identity and ethics, and preparation for employment. Documentation of challenges and resolutions was comparatively less consistent and was therefore coded E3.

The findings indicate that teaching portfolios can make important aspects of pre-service teacher development visible. They document not only completed instructional products but also reflection, adaptation, professional identity formation, and connections between coursework and classroom practice. The results support the use of portfolios as developmental and assessment resources, consistent with the literature on authentic assessment, reflective practice, and professional learning.

The findings on professional readiness provide evidence of documented preparation for teaching, including instructional competence, theory-to-practice application, professional identity and ethics, and employability-related experiences. However, these findings should not be interpreted as direct evidence of employment outcomes or generalized teacher effectiveness because the study analyzed a small, purposively selected set of portfolios.

Overall, the study concludes that teaching portfolios can serve as meaningful documentary records of reflective growth, learning quality, and professional readiness among



BTLED pre-service teachers. The study contributes a cross-portfolio analytic perspective for a Philippine state-university context and provides a basis for strengthening portfolio design, assessment criteria, and reflective practices in teacher education. Future research should strengthen methodological rigor through independent coding, broader sampling, external validation of the coding framework, and triangulation with other sources of evidence.

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